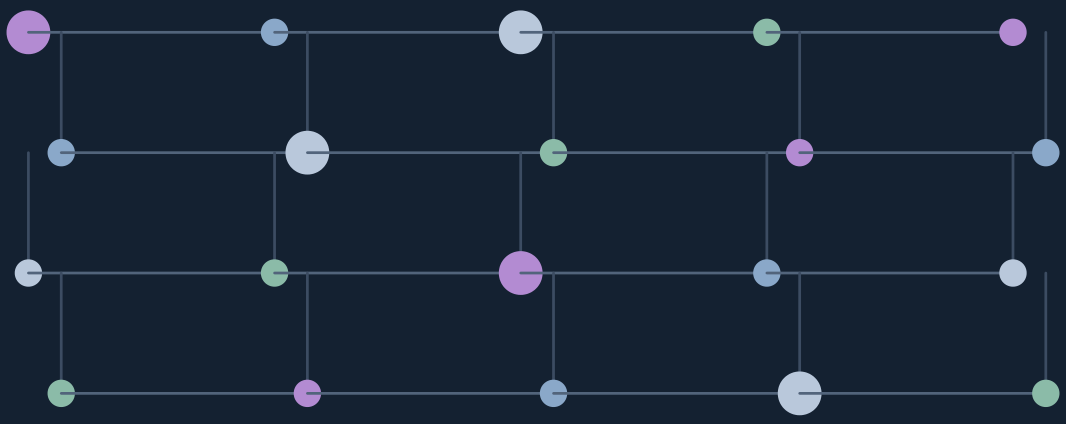
Twenty games for language learning.

A game-first concept collection for Linguist

Games people would choose to play, with sounds, words and meaning woven into the decisions that make play interesting.



Linguist is a space-themed language-learning app. This collection is for discussing possible games for English-speaking adults starting French, with room to expand into other languages and skills. It is a menu of ideas, not twenty planned features.

Play comes first

Strategy, discovery, skill, surprise or social interaction—not a quiz wearing a game skin.

Language changes play

Knowing the sound or meaning changes what you can do, choose or understand.

Different ways in

Audio-led games, fully silent games, relaxed options and room for broader language skills.

1 November 2026 · Concepts for discussion

Find your kind of game

Twenty distinct play loops, from a short solo run to a cooperative adventure.

A **phoneme** is a distinctive speech sound. Here, a “sound family” groups words containing the same target sound: French ***/u/*** in *tout*, for example, differs from ***/y/*** in *tu*.

#	Game	Play style	Audio	Practice focus
01	**Signal Match**	Match-three puzzle	Required	Phoneme identification
02	**Orbit Chains**	Word-chain puzzle	Optional	Sound–spelling associations
03	**Word Fall**	Falling-object arcade	Silent	Rapid written-word classification
04	**Echo Bubbles**	Bubble shooter	Required	Auditory sound-family matching
05	**Sound Current**	Rhythm routing	Required	Fast auditory categorization
06	**Vowel Rally**	Branching-route racer	Required	Listening under changing context
07	**Cargo Shift**	Crate-pushing logic puzzle	Silent	Word pronunciation and classification
08	**Sentence Circuit**	Pipe-and-network puzzle	Silent	Word order and grammatical agreement
09	**Word Forge**	Tactical deckbuilder	Silent	Vocabulary and sentence construction
10	**Constellation Heist**	Stealth and route planning	Required	Listening for useful information
11	**Lost in the Station**	Hidden-object investigation	Optional	Vocabulary and descriptive comprehension
12	**Station Orders**	Time-management game	Optional	Everyday vocabulary, quantities and attributes
13	**Signal Defense**	Tower-defense strategy	Optional	Sound families or semantic categories
14	**Echo Vault**	Audio memory game	Required	Phoneme grouping across words
15	**Letter Nebula**	Letter-grid word finding	Silent	Spelling and vocabulary retrieval
16	**One Odd Signal**	Social deduction	Optional	Vocabulary, paraphrase and comparison
17	**Rescue Duo**	Asymmetric cooperative navigation	Co-op speech	Directions and communication
18	**Verb Gravity**	Physics puzzle	Silent	Action vocabulary in context
19	**First Contact**	Branching investigation adventure	Optional	Reading and conversational meaning
20	**Vowel Constellations**	Latin-square deduction puzzle	Silent	Pronunciation knowledge and sound grouping

Audio: Required needs recordings; Optional has a silent written version; Silent needs no sound; Co-op speech uses people talking. **Scope:** Small = compact prototype; Medium = a fuller puzzle system; Large = substantial systems, content, music, art or cooperation. These are relative editorial estimates, not schedules or budgets.

Learning descriptions are proposed practice opportunities, not demonstrated outcomes. Game scores can reflect motor skill, memory and strategy as well as language. None of these concepts requires automatic pronunciation grading.

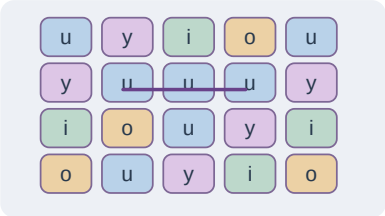
Boards with staying power

Matching and route-finding with room to plan.

01 Signal Match

Match-three puzzle · Required · Medium scope

Build a huge cascade while chasing the vowel you just heard.



The game. Swap neighboring sound gems to make lines, create special tiles and set up cascades. A spoken French word sets the sound family your mission needs. Other matches can reshape the board, but collecting the heard family advances the objective. Choose between an immediate target match and a larger setup that could produce a powerful clear.

Why play again? Board planning, chain reactions, near-misses and the satisfaction of a well-timed special tile.

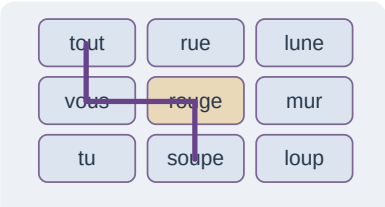
Language inside play. Recognizing the vowel determines the useful match. For example, hearing tout points toward /u/, while tu points toward /y/. Automatic cascades remain game events, not extra listening answers.

Make-or-break. Keep the target active long enough to play strategically. A new recording before every small move would turn the board into a waiting room.

02 Orbit Chains

Word-chain puzzle · Optional · Medium scope

Find the long chain that cracks the board wide open.



The game. Connect neighboring word tiles belonging to the target sound family. Diagonals, branching opportunities, outlined obstacles and row-clearing stars create competing routes. A short chain may crack an obstacle; a longer one may earn a special tile and set up the next board. The target can be displayed silently or introduced by a spoken cue.

Why play again? Spotting a route others miss, choosing when to cash it in and engineering long combo chains.

Language inside play. Players repeatedly classify real written words by pronunciation. A /u/ chain might include tout, vous and rouge. Silent play practices word/sound knowledge; it does not demonstrate listening ability.

Make-or-break. Do not color-code each word with its correct family. The words need to matter, and long chains should reward planning rather than random dragging.

Arcade reactions

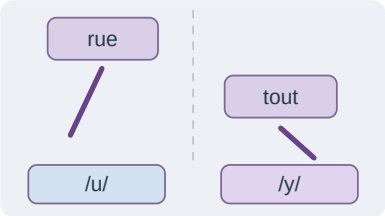
Continuous motion, clean inputs and rewarding chains.

03 Word Fall

Falling-object arcade · Silent · Small scope

One more clean swipe. Keep the streak alive.

The game. Several words fall through an asteroid field. Choose which pod to rescue first, swipe it left or right into its sound-family dock, and decide when to bank a growing streak rather than risk it through the next wave. Correct sorts increase the multiplier; mistakes and missed pods threaten the unbanked combo. Words keep arriving without a Next button.



Why play again? Prioritizing simultaneous threats, close saves and deciding when to bank a streak or push your luck.

Language inside play. The player must know which phoneme a written word contains. French /u/ versus /y/ is a natural first contrast. A missed word is a game miss, not evidence that the player chose the wrong phoneme.

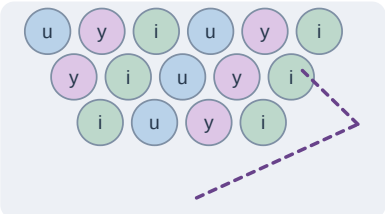
Make-or-break. Multiple pods and speed can overwhelm reading. Offer slower waves and equivalent tap/keyboard controls; missed words are game misses, not automatically wrong phoneme answers.

04 Echo Bubbles

Bubble shooter · Required · Medium scope

Bank a shot, connect the right sound and drop an entire cluster.

The game. A word recording identifies the sound carried by your next bubble. Aim it into a ceiling of labeled sound bubbles, using wall bounces and narrow gaps to connect a matching group. Clearing support bubbles can drop a much larger cluster. Decide whether to take a safe direct shot or risk a bank shot for a bigger collapse.



Why play again? Aiming, geometric prediction, risky bank shots and large cluster drops.

Language inside play. The heard vowel tells the player which existing group will accept the shot. Sound labels and consistent shapes make the connection learnable without relying on color alone.

Make-or-break. A missed shot mixes aim with listening. Keep those outcomes separate, and give the audio enough lead time for an actual aiming decision.

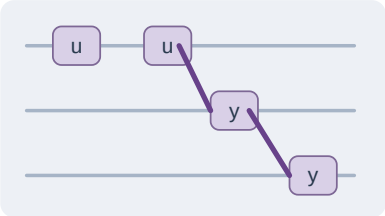
Timing and movement

Language joins rhythm and physical control.

05 Sound Current

Rhythm routing · Required · Large scope

Ride the beat and route a stream of signals through the right lanes.



The game. Short spoken cues enter a rhythmic conveyor. Switch their route toward the matching sound lane, then time the transfer to keep the musical phrase going. Patterns build from simple alternating flows to syncopated crossings. Good runs add musical layers; mistakes thin the arrangement instead of stopping the song.

Why play again? Rhythmic flow, pattern anticipation, increasingly intricate routing and music that responds to play.

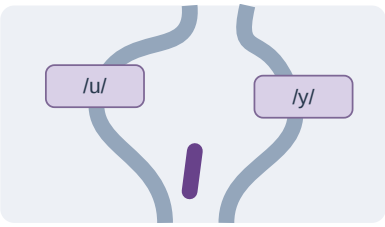
Language inside play. The sound category selects the route, while timing provides the arcade challenge. Use a small authored contrast set before introducing more sounds.

Make-or-break. Poor rhythm performance must not be labeled poor hearing. Separate route correctness from timing, and include a lower-pressure practice setting.

06 Vowel Rally

Branching-route racer · Required · Large scope

Take the sound gate that sets up the best racing line.



The game. Pilot a craft along a winding course with forks, drifting turns and shortcut gates. A spoken cue arrives ahead of each fork. The matching sound gate opens the useful route, but the player still chooses how to approach the corner and whether a risky shortcut is worth taking. Driving continues between language decisions.

Why play again? Momentum, clean corners, shortcuts and mastering a course over repeated runs.

Language inside play. Understanding the cue changes the route available. Later variants could use direction words or short instructions rather than phoneme families.

Make-or-break. Allow enough time between hearing and steering. A collision is not automatically a listening error, and reading must not be demanded in a tight corner.

Planning and construction

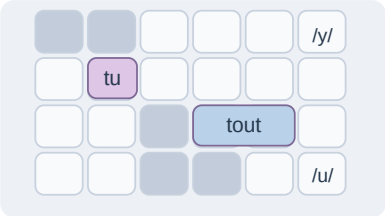
Understand the words, then solve the spatial problem.

07 Cargo Shift

Crate-pushing logic puzzle · Silent · Medium scope

The right word is easy to recognize; getting its crate there is the puzzle.

The game. Push word-labeled cargo crates onto phoneme docks in a cramped space warehouse. Crates cannot be pulled, corridors can jam, and placing one crate too early may block another. Plan the entire loading sequence, use undo freely and solve each board with a satisfying final arrangement.



Why play again? Spatial planning, clever reversals, avoiding deadlocks and compact handcrafted puzzles.

Language inside play. Pronunciation knowledge determines which dock each word belongs on. The same structure could later sort vocabulary into semantic categories, with a clearly labeled change of learning goal.

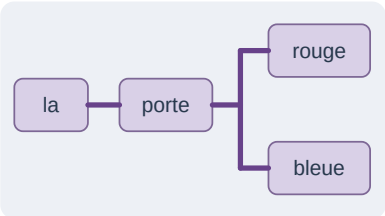
Make-or-break. Automatic family colors would remove the language decision. Unknown words need accessible help so the puzzle is challenging rather than dependent on guessing.

08 Sentence Circuit

Pipe-and-network puzzle · Silent · Large scope

Build a sentence that also closes the circuit.

The game. Rotate and place word-bearing circuit pieces between a source and destination. A working route needs both physical connections and a valid authored phrase. At one fork, la porte rouge powers the red-door branch while la porte bleue powers the blue-door branch. Both phrases work, but obstacles and limited junction pieces make their routes strategically different.



Why play again? Network planning, multiple solutions and the moment a complete path lights up.

Language inside play. Word order and agreement determine valid connections. Begin with a small set of taught nouns, articles, adjectives and verbs; expand through authored phrase patterns.

Make-or-break. If connector shapes reveal every correct grammatical link, language becomes irrelevant. If grammar is unconstrained, validation becomes unreliable. Both layers need careful authoring.

Runs and infiltration

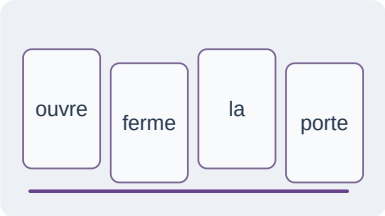
Use knowledge to shape a strategy or uncover an opportunity.

09 Word Forge

Tactical deckbuilder · Silent · Large scope

Build the word combination that turns a bad hand into a winning move.

The game. Draw word cards and combine them into short valid commands that activate ship abilities. From a hand containing ouvre, ferme, la and porte, ouvre la porte can open a shortcut while ferme la porte can block a pursuing drone. Choose which effect matters now, which cards to keep and how to shape the deck during a run.



Why play again? Card synergies, improvising with a limited hand, tactical tradeoffs and different builds on each run.

Language inside play. Useful combinations require recalling word meanings and constructing taught phrase patterns. Cards have game consequences, so vocabulary affects available strategy.

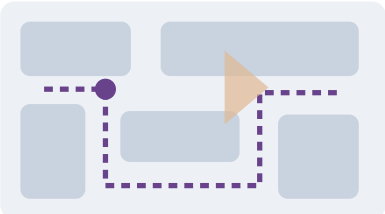
Make-or-break. A fixed sentence with one missing card is just a quiz. Support several valid tactical phrases. Start with authored combinations rather than promising unrestricted language understanding.

10 Constellation Heist

Stealth and route planning · Required · Large scope

Listen from cover, learn the patrol plan and slip through the gap.

The game. Move through a station with guard patrols, doors and safe hiding places. Short intercepted messages reveal a patrol destination, a door state or a route hint. Combine the information with what you can see, then choose when and where to move. Replays are available from safe cover.



Why play again? Sneaking, observing systems, planning a route and escaping a near detection.

Language inside play. Understanding simple French directions, locations and descriptions gives the player an informational advantage. The language is part of discovering the world rather than a checkpoint question.

Make-or-break. The player needs usable clues at beginner level. Failure may reflect route timing, so the game should not infer a specific language mistake from getting caught.

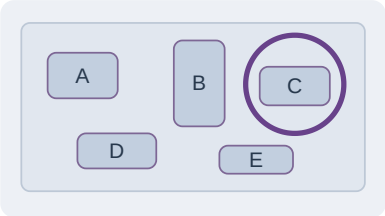
Observation and busy worlds

Find meaning in a scene or keep several jobs moving.

11 Lost in the Station

Hidden-object investigation · Optional · Large scope

Find the object that makes all the clues fit.



The game. Explore a busy station scene full of plausible objects and small environmental puzzles. Written or spoken clues narrow the search: color, size, location, owner or purpose. Some discoveries reveal a new area or explain another clue. The challenge is observation and deduction, not choosing one of three labeled pictures.

Why play again? Visual discovery, clue combinations, amusing scene details and revealing hidden spaces.

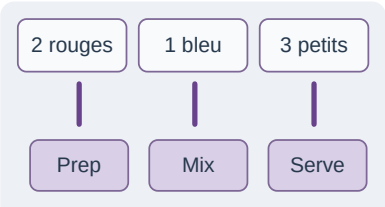
Language inside play. Words for objects, attributes and spatial relations become useful search tools. Multiple clues encourage comprehension beyond recognizing a single noun.

Make-or-break. Custom scene art and clue authoring are substantial work. Avoid English labels that let the player bypass the target language.

12 Station Orders

Time-management game · Optional · Large scope

Keep a tiny space café running when every order arrives at once.



The game. Prepare and deliver orders across several workstations. Read incoming tickets, choose ingredients, start preparation and decide which job to serve next. Recipes take different amounts of time, so batching and queue management matter. A relaxed shift removes time pressure while retaining the production puzzle.

Why play again? Controlled chaos, efficient workflows, recovering from a messy queue and improving a personal shift.

Language inside play. French object names, quantities and attributes determine what gets prepared. For example, an order might specify two red drinks rather than one blue drink. Spoken tickets can be an optional later mode.

Make-or-break. Keep the French meaningful without making every recipe a translation popup. Timer failures and incorrect order interpretation are different outcomes.

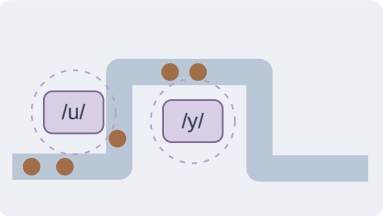
Defense and memory

Choose a plan, then remember or adapt.

13 Signal Defense

Tower-defense strategy · Optional · Large scope

Build the defense that can handle the next kind of wave.



The game. Place relays along an enemy route and equip them with word modules. In this game, /u/ modules slow enemies while /y/ modules hit groups. Equip tout in a /u/ relay before a bend to extend a kill zone, or tu in a /y/ relay near a crowded junction for area damage. Limited positions force choices about coverage and which words to deploy.

Why play again? Planning coverage, adapting to waves and discovering combinations that cover one another’s weaknesses.

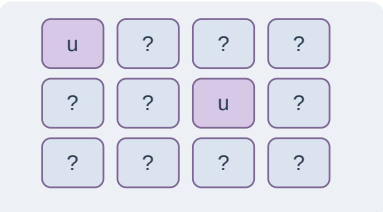
Language inside play. Correctly classifying the available words determines which tactical combinations will work. Written modules allow silent play; a spoken-module variant could train heard categories. The fictional abilities belong to the game, not to the real sounds.

Make-or-break. Placement and reassignment must require language decisions inside play, not a quiz between automatic waves. Automated shots are not extra learner answers.

14 Echo Vault

Audio memory game · Required · Small scope

Remember where you heard the matching vowel—not the matching word.



The game. Explore a grid of hidden signal tiles containing several vowel families. Flip a small number at a time, hear their words and clear any pair sharing the same vowel. Cleared pairs can expose bonus paths or allow a longer sequence of flips. The layout changes each run while the player builds a mental map of what is where.

Why play again? Memory, deduction, choosing which uncertainty to test and the satisfaction of a remembered pair.

Language inside play. A pair could be tout and vous rather than two copies of tout. Matching across different words asks the player to attend to the shared sound instead of identical recordings.

Make-or-break. Memory performance is not the same as phoneme knowledge. Keep mismatches informative and avoid interpreting every forgotten location as a language error.

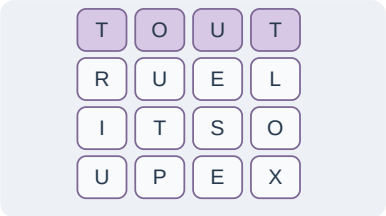
Discovery and deduction

Find useful words or read the other players.

15 Letter Nebula

Letter-grid word finding · Silent · Medium scope

Find the overlooked word that opens a new part of the grid.



The game. Trace neighboring letters to form words. Longer finds clear larger paths or expose fresh letters; blocked sectors and limited-use star tiles create planning choices. Missions ask for a sound family or semantic theme, so the player searches the board with a purpose rather than submitting any sequence of letters.

Why play again? Word discovery, spotting long routes, transforming the letter board and competing against a personal best.

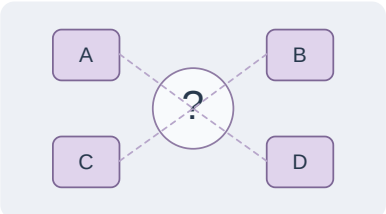
Language inside play. The player retrieves and spells real words, then connects them to the current category. An early French mission could use a taught vocabulary set before opening broader dictionaries.

Make-or-break. French phonemes cannot be validated by letter matching alone. Use authored word membership, and do not promise an unrestricted dictionary in the first prototype.

16 One Odd Signal

Social deduction · Optional · Large scope

Describe your secret word well enough to belong—without revealing too much.



The game. Three or four players receive private word clues; four players are recommended. One player has a subtly different clue. Give short hints, notice inconsistent descriptions and decide who holds the odd signal. The odd player tries to blend in and infer the group’s word. Start with pass-and-play on one device; typed hints permit silent group play.

Why play again? Bluffing, reading other people, carefully chosen clues and surprising reveals.

Language inside play. Players actively use vocabulary and compare meanings or sound-related clues. A small taught word bank can support beginners; richer paraphrasing suits learners with more vocabulary. Hints may be typed or spoken in person.

Make-or-break. Social skill and language skill interact. Do not grade language proficiency from the vote, and do not make online multiplayer a prerequisite for testing the idea.

Communication and physical puzzles

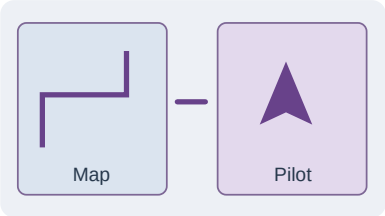
Use language to coordinate people or change the world.

17 Rescue Duo

Asymmetric cooperative navigation · Co-op speech · Large scope

One player has the route. The other has the controls. Neither can finish alone.

The game. A navigator sees clues and a route map while a pilot steers around hazards. They must communicate which turn, landmark or action comes next. Roles swap between short missions. Both sides have useful choices: the navigator chooses a safe route and the pilot decides how to execute it.



Why play again? Shared problem-solving, communication mishaps, coordinated saves and improving together.

Language inside play. French direction words and short phrases become tools for accomplishing a shared goal. Beginner phrase banks can support the first missions. People can speak in the same room; microphone recording or automatic pronunciation scoring is unnecessary.

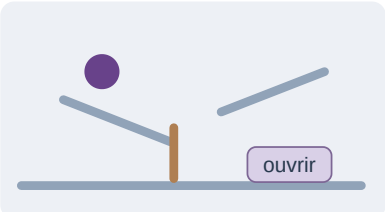
Make-or-break. Both roles need agency. If one player only reads translations while the other gets all the gameplay, the design has failed. Two-player coordination increases scope.

18 Verb Gravity

Physics puzzle · Silent · Large scope

Change the right mechanism and let physics do the rest.

The game. Guide a stranded object or craft to an exit by operating switches, platforms, doors and moving surfaces. French verb controls change the environment: open, close, push, pull or turn. Order and timing matter; the player can experiment, reset and discover several workable solutions.



Why play again? Physical experimentation, chain reactions and the delight of a machine finally doing what you intended.

Language inside play. Verb meanings repeatedly produce visible consequences in the world. The words are actions the player uses, not labels on an answer sheet.

Make-or-break. The mechanism must remain understandable, and arbitrary trial-and-error should not be mistaken for comprehension. Introduce a small taught verb set with consistent behavior.

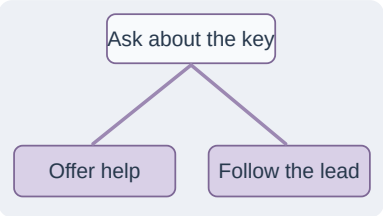
Stories and quiet logic

Understand what is possible, then choose your next move.

19 First Contact

Branching investigation adventure · Optional · Large scope

Get the information you need without closing the wrong door.



The game. Investigate a station mystery through conversations, observations and small environmental puzzles. Choose what to ask, how to respond and which lead to pursue. Different valid responses can gain different information or change a character’s willingness to help. The story adapts to the approach rather than stopping for a translation question.

Why play again? Curiosity, meaningful choices, discoveries and replaying a case with a different approach.

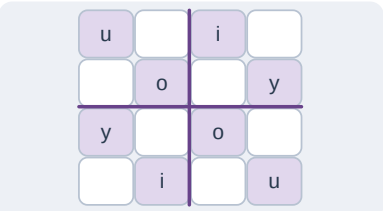
Language inside play. Understanding French phrases changes what the player can infer or negotiate. Start with short, authored beginner exchanges; optional voices could add listening practice.

Make-or-break. Meaningful branches require substantial writing and review. Avoid a single obviously correct response at every exchange, and avoid unproven automatic free-text grading.

20 Vowel Constellations

Latin-square deduction puzzle · Silent · Medium scope

Solve the grid by combining word knowledge with logic.



The game. Arrange word tiles in a 4×4 constellation grid. Each row, column and outlined 2×2 region must contain one word from each of four sound families. Fixed clues constrain the category pattern; use pronunciation knowledge and elimination to place the rest. Different words within one family are deliberately interchangeable, so any arrangement satisfying the rules wins.

Why play again? Elimination, logical breakthroughs and compact puzzles that reward patient reasoning.

Language inside play. Recognizing a word’s vowel category makes it usable in a deduction. A four-family board could use /u/, /y/, /i/ and /o/, introduced only after those sounds are familiar.

Make-or-break. Do not reveal all categories through colors. Unknown pronunciations need optional help, and solving by grid logic alone should not be reported as independent sound mastery.

Choose what is worth playing

A small shortlist is more useful than committing to all twenty.

Start by picking a game you would enjoy even before hearing its learning pitch. Then ask whether the language genuinely changes its interesting decisions.

Three contrasting first prototypes

03 · Word Fall

Tests a fast, silent arcade loop with prioritization and push-your-luck combos. Watch whether sorting stays readable under pressure.

07 · Cargo Shift

Tests patient spatial strategy without audio or reaction-speed demands. Watch whether word knowledge matters to planning.

01 · Signal Match

Tests a familiar replayable board with heard targets. Watch whether audio enriches the puzzle instead of interrupting it.

These are editorial starting suggestions, not selected features. For a broader-language direction, compare Station Orders, Word Forge and First Contact. For shared play, compare One Odd Signal and Rescue Duo.

Your shortlist

Write three concept numbers, or use the Shortlist buttons in the HTML version. Share the reasons as well as the choices.

First: _____ Second: _____ Third: _____

1 Which game would you voluntarily play for another five minutes? What would make you come back?

2 Where does understanding the language change a meaningful choice? Could the player bypass it through colors, position or guessing?

3 What needs testing first: fun, controls, content, pacing, audio, accessibility or learning transfer?

A useful next step is a small playable prototype, not a polished exercise screen. Test enjoyment and the learning mechanism separately. Use explicit, reviewed language content for a real release; unfamiliar-word/speaker and delayed checks are needed before claiming transfer. Preserve learning records separately from puzzle scores.